



WE'RE GONNA STICK TOGETHER, JUST LIKE IT USED TO BE

THE WILD BUNCH / 1969

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Western

DIRECTOR
Sam Peckinpah

WRITERS
Walton Green, Sam Peckinpah (screenplay); Walton Green, Roy N. Sickner (story)

STARS
William Holden, Ernest Borgnine, Robert Ryan, Warren Oates

BEFORE
1961 Peckinpah's first movie as director is *The Deadly Companions*, a classic, low-budget Western.

AFTER
1970 Peckinpah's next movie, another Western, *The Ballad of Cable Hogue*, shows a change in pace with far less violence.

1977 Peckinpah's *Cross of Iron* is an unflinching portrayal of a soldier's life in World War II.

The *Wild Bunch* gleefully deconstructs the ethos of the traditional Western.

The lines between heroes and villains are blurred, and characters are not always rewarded for doing the right thing.

Set in 1913, the story contains certain motifs of the traditional Western. The aging thieves—the “bunch”—arrange one last bank job, which inevitably goes horribly wrong. They are chased into Mexico by their old comrade Deke Thornton (Robert Ryan), who has reluctantly switched sides and is leading a group of hopeless bounty hunters. The old West is fast disappearing, a fact made clear by the German

machine gun at the center of the final shootout, presaging the slaughter that was to come in World War I.

In awe of violence

Each time a character is hit with a bullet, no matter how minor, the moment of impact is filmed in slow motion. We see the blood spurt out of the back in close-up, as the body contorts toward the ground. The sound drains out of the scene until all we hear is the character's death rattle. Slow motion does not appear in any other context.

The violence of the old West was notorious, but *The Wild Bunch* is the first movie to stand back and look on it with such awe. The movie



Sam Peckinpah Director

Sam Peckinpah was born in California in 1925. After serving in the

US marines in World War II, he worked as an assistant to Don Siegel on movies including *Invasion of The Body Snatchers* (1956). His first movie as director came in 1961 with *The Deadly Companions*. Peckinpah soon

earned himself a reputation for bad behavior on set. He suffered alcohol problems, and died of heart failure in 1984.

Key movies

1962 *Ride the High Country*
1969 *The Wild Bunch*
1971 *Straw Dogs*
1974 *Bring Me the Head of Alfredo Garcia*